

HOUSE BILL 1975

By White

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,
relative to career readiness.

WHEREAS, the General Assembly intends by this act to enhance career readiness and exploration for Tennessee high school students by integrating nationally recognized, industry-aligned career readiness and exploration tools into public school curricula, incentivizing student participation, and fostering collaboration with local employers to prepare students for high-wage, high-demand careers; now, therefore,

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 11, is amended by adding the following as a new part:

49-11-1001. Short title.

This part is known and may be cited as the "Tennessee Career Readiness Enhancement Act."

49-11-1002. Part definitions.

As used in this part:

(1) "Career readiness tools" means digital platforms and assessments that provide:

(A) Personalized career exploration based on student interests, skills, and local labor market data, aligned with the United States department of labor's O*NET framework or a successor framework for an occupational information program operated by the United States department of labor;

(B) Stackable credentials in essential soft skills, employability skills, and digital literacy skills, recognized by national workforce councils; and

(C) Integration with work-based learning opportunities to connect students with career pathways;

(2) "Department" means the department of education;

(3) "High school" means a public school or public charter school that serves students in any of the grades eleven and twelve (11-12); and

(4) "Work-based learning" means structured learning experiences that connect classroom instruction to real-world work environments.

49-11-1003. Integration into career and technical education programs.

(a) Beginning with the 2026-2027 school year, each high school in this state shall integrate career readiness tools into at least one (1) career and technical education (CTE) course offered to students in grades eleven (11) and twelve (12).

(b) The career readiness tools that are integrated pursuant to subsection (a) must enable students to earn nationally recognized credentials in essential soft skills, employability skills, and digital literacy skills at no cost to the students.

(c) Prior to integrating career readiness tools into a CTE course pursuant to subsection (a), each LEA of a high school and public charter school that is a high school shall obtain approval for the career readiness tools from the department. The department shall approve the career readiness tools if the department finds that the career readiness tools align with this state's career readiness opportunity program and the United States department of labor's O*NET framework or a successor framework for an occupational information program operated by the United States department of labor.

49-11-1004. Student Incentives.

(a) A student who successfully completes an assessment associated with career readiness tools and earns a credential in essential soft skills, employability skills, or digital literacy skills is eligible to receive up to one (1) elective credit per credential, not to exceed a total of three (3) elective credits, toward high school graduation requirements as set by the state board of education pursuant to § 49-6-6001.

(b) The department shall establish a micro-grant program, funded through state appropriations or existing federal grants, to provide a stipend of up to one hundred dollars (\$100) to each student who earns three (3) stackable credentials offered through the career readiness tools. The state board of education shall promulgate rules to establish and administer the micro-grant program in accordance with the Uniform Administrative Procedures Act, compiled in title 4, chapter 5.

49-11-1005. Teacher training and support.

The department shall provide professional development programs for career and technical (CTE) educators and school counselors on the use of career readiness tools for career exploration, skill development, and credential attainment. The professional development programs developed pursuant to this section must include modules on integrating career readiness tools into classroom instruction and work-based learning experiences.

49-11-1006. Employer partnerships.

(a) An LEA of a high school or public charter school governing body that is a high school may partner with local businesses and industries to promote credentials earned through career readiness tools pursuant to this part as a hiring criterion.

(b)

(1) The department shall establish a pilot program for at least ten (10) school districts or public charter schools to integrate career readiness tools into work-based learning experiences in the 2027-2028 school year.

(2) The pilot program must include mechanisms for employer feedback to validate the relevance of credentials to workforce needs.

(3) The department shall report findings from the pilot program based on employer feedback to the general assembly by July 1, 2029.

(4) The state board of education shall promulgate rules to establish and administer the pilot program in accordance with the Uniform Administrative Procedures Act, compiled in Title 4, Chapter 5.

49-11-1007. Accountability and reporting.

Beginning July 1, 2027, and each July 1 thereafter, the department shall collect and report to the general assembly data on the number of students completing credentials through career readiness tools for the immediately preceding school year, disaggregated by school district, student demographics, and credential type.

SECTION 2. The state board of education shall promulgate rules to effectuate this act. The rules must be promulgated in accordance with the Uniform Administrative Procedures Act, compiled in Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 4, Chapter 5.

SECTION 3. If any provision of this act or its application to any person or circumstance is held invalid, then the invalidity does not affect other provisions or applications of the act that can be given effect without the invalid provision or application, and to that end, the provisions of this act are severable.

SECTION 4. The headings in this act are for reference purposes only and do not constitute a part of the law enacted by this act. However, the Tennessee Code Commission is requested to include the headings in any compilation or publication containing this act.

SECTION 5. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it, and applies to the 2026-2027 school year and subsequent school years.